

AI-Designed Portrait Guide #010

Difficulty **Advanced** Est. time **10-14 hours** Subject **Adult Female Portrait / Professional Headshot**

Pencils **Prismacolor Premier**

• COLOR PALETTE



Ginger Root

PC1084

Dominant warm skin base (measured #ddc3a9 match); core local color across face and neck



90% French Grey

PC1076

Dark anchor and dominant shadow value (measured #2e2b2e match); hair depth and cast shadows



Black

PC935

Deepest pupil, iris rim, and shadow extremes (measured #050a14 match); final dark punch



Espresso

PC1099

Chromatic shadow undertone (measured #59473e match); core shadow in cheeks, jaw, neck



Light Umber

PC941

Skin shadow middleman (measured #8d6651 match); warm shadow plane form-



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Skin tone transition (measured #b29376 match); cheek and mid-face mid-tone



70% Warm Grey

PC1056

Shadow plane optical mixing (measured #6a594e match); warm shadow under-layer



70% French Grey

PC1074

Approximate mid-tone anchor (measured #9f7d63 match); blending bridge in shadow zones



Peach

PC939

Warm highlight undertone and cheek accent; light-struck zones on forehead and cheekbones



Peach Beige

PC1085

Lightest warm skin layer; luminous mid-face and light-facing planes before burnish



Salmon Pink

PC1001

Optical mixing undertone for skin glow; applied early under warm base for



Clay Rose

PC1017

Cheek saturation and lip color; warm accent in facial features



Rosy Beige

PC1019

Face-to-neck transition and soft mid-tone; unification glaze across skin zones



Bronze

PC1028

Chromatic shadow accent in warm light zones; jaw and cheek definition



Henna

PC1031

Rich warm shadow depth; nasolabial fold and ear shadow



Blue Violet Lake

PC1079

Cool shadow undertone in eye sockets and under-jaw; chromatic complement to warm skin



White

PC938

Final peak highlight and burnishing base; eye specular highlight



Cream

PC914

Soft burnishing layer and warm final glaze; sclera (eye white) and light skin planes

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

<i>What is the subject?</i>	Adult female professional headshot, front-facing to slightly angled view, with dark styled hair, medium-warm complexion, and professional portrait lighting. Features are well-defined with good bone structure and clear expression.
<i>Material characteristics</i>	Photographic portrait reference with professional studio lighting; smooth skin modeling, crisp focus on face and eyes, subtle directional light creating clear highlight and shadow zones without harsh extremes.
<i>Geometric structure</i>	Head sits upright on visible neck; three-quarter or frontal face with symmetrical feature placement; jaw and cheekbones provide strong form; neck transitions into dark garment at lower frame edge; hair pulled back or styled upward, revealing full face structure.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

<i>Light source direction</i>	Soft directional light from upper-left to left-front, typical of professional portrait studio setup; produces even face illumination with gentle modeling shadows rather than drama.
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HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex, bridge of nose, nose tip, upper cheekbones, and center of lower lip; warm-lit zones with crisp edge breaks where light transitions to shadow.

LIGHT AREA

Full lit side of face including forehead, lit cheek, temple, and upper jaw; mid-tone warmth with strong saturation.

MIDTONE

Center face from eyebrows through nose to upper lip; the major transition zone between highlight and shadow, carrying peak skin saturation.

SHADOW

Eye sockets (especially upper lid cast shadow), under-eye, nasolabial folds, under-nose, jaw-to-neck corner, and ear; shadows remain warm-toned and translucent rather than black.

CAST SHADOW

Upper eyelid drop shadow defining eye depth; subtle shadow under lower lip; soft shadow on neck from jaw overhang; garment edge creates dark boundary at lower frame.

Edge quality notes

Soft edges throughout (portrait studio diffusion); the upper eyelid cast shadow is the single sharpest edge; jaw-to-neck transition is soft and integrated; lit planes fade gradually into shadows with no harsh lines except where garment meets skin.

COLOR ANALYSIS

Overall temperature

Consistently warm across the face — the dominant measured skin tone is #ddc3a9 (Ginger Root, PC1084), a warm medium tan. Light zones shift warmer toward cream and peach; shadow zones remain warm-toned (olive, espresso, warm sienna) rather than cool-grey.

Light zone tendency

Lit areas (forehead, nose bridge, cheekbones, chin) intensify toward warm cream, light peach, and pale salmon; highlights preserve warmth and never become cool or stark.

Shadow zone tendency

Shadow planes (cheeks, jaw, under-eye, neck) shift into warm chromatic darks — espresso, warm grey, sienna, light umber — maintaining color integrity rather than turning neutral or muddy grey. Core shadow edges stay defined and warm.

Special color areas

Eyes carry blue-violet undertones in the iris and socket shadow; lips shift toward warm rose and sienna; cheeks concentrate saturation as warm clay-rose and peach blush; neck carries slightly cooler undertones than face but remains warm-biased overall.

Saturation distribution Peak saturation in eyes (iris and pupil) and lips; secondary saturation in cheek apples and nose tip; mid-saturation across mid-face skin; shadow zones desaturate gradually toward grey-brown but retain warm cast; background and dark garment read as desaturated very dark grey-black.

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01 Step 1: Monochrome Value Map – Full Face

Entire visible face, ear, and upper neck

Monochrome value underpainting with circular blending strokes; place darks first as anchors, then light wash across lit zones; work light to medium pressure, no burnishing yet.

Light to Medium pressure

Establish the full tonal range with a single neutral pencil before introducing color. Using PC1076 (90% French Grey), block the darkest values first — upper eyelid shadow, pupil, deep nasal shadow, and jaw underside — at medium pressure to create value anchors. Then lay a light, even wash of the same pencil across the entire lit side of the face to establish midtone baseline. This monochrome pass clarifies form without color confusion and ensures no area is left unplanned. Work with circular, blending strokes where light and shadow meet to avoid hard lines at this stage.

COLORS ☒ PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *This foundation pass prevents the common 'patchy color' problem by forcing you to plan the full tonal structure before any hue is introduced. Squint at the reference to see value, not color, and match that squint view here.*

02 Step 2: Eye Structure – Pupil, Iris Rim, and Upper Lid Cast Shadow

Both eyes; pupil, iris circle, and upper eyelid shadow

Place pupils and iris rim first with black at medium-heavy pressure, preserve single white specular highlight; block upper lid shadow with 90% French Grey using directional downward strokes following lid shape; fade shadow softly outward.

Medium to Heavy (pupils and rim); Medium (upper lid shadow) pressure

Define eye depth and dimensionality before building iris detail. Using PC935 (Black), place a small, slightly oval pupil at medium-heavy pressure in the center of each eye, leaving a tiny white paper glint at the upper-inner edge for specular highlight (do not color over this). Draw a thin dark rim around the iris perimeter with PC935, then use PC1076 (90% French Grey) to block the upper eyelid cast shadow with medium pressure, following the natural upper lid contour. This establishes the darkest dark in the portrait and creates the eye socket depth that anchors all subsequent layering. The cast shadow should fade softly toward the outer corner, not remain uniform.

COLORS

☒ PC935 Black

☐ PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *The specular highlight is your brightest point in the entire portrait — preserve pure paper white here, never color it. This one dot of light reads as the light source for the whole eye and face; protecting it from the start guarantees impact in the final image.*

03 Step 3: Iris Color Build – Radial Layers and Depth

Iris ring in both eyes

Prismatic radial layering: blue-violet base, peach warm undertone, light peach highlight on dome; short radial strokes from pupil outward; light pressure throughout to preserve transparency.

Light pressure

Build iris color using prismatic layering (distinct hues laid in thin passes) rather than a single premixed iris color. Start with PC1079 (Blue Violet Lake) applied in light concentric rings radiating outward from the pupil rim, using short radial strokes that follow the iris's natural radial fiber pattern. Layer PC939 (Peach) as a secondary warm undertone through the lower iris to shift color temperature and add dimension. Finally, accent the upper iris arc with PC1085 (Peach Beige) at very light pressure to suggest light reflection across the iris dome. Keep all iris strokes light and transparent — the iris is a small, delicate feature that turns muddy if overworked. The dark rim you placed in Step 2 remains the darkest element.

COLORS



PC1079 Blue Violet Lake



PC939 Peach



PC1085 Peach Beige

✦ *Iris color in colored pencil always reads more vibrant and alive when built from multiple hues layered thin rather than one dense color. The blue-violet base plus warm peach creates optical color mixing that reads as depth and translucence — the iris appears to have volume, not lie flat.*

04 Step 4: Sclera (Eye White) and Under-Eye Zone

White of eye (sclera) and lower eyelid shadow

Sclera blocked with light cream at light pressure; cool blue-violet undertone in under-eye shadow at very light pressure; blend upper lid shadow downward softly; lower lash line stays softer than upper line.

Light pressure

Block the sclera with PC914 (Cream) at light pressure across the visible white of the eye, avoiding the specular highlight from Step 2. The sclera is never pure white — cream preserves the eye's form and avoids the flat 'cartoonish' appearance pure white creates. For the lower eyelid and under-eye shadow, apply PC1079 (Blue Violet Lake) at very light pressure to introduce cool undertone that contrasts with the warm face, creating dimensional separation. Blend the upper eyelid shadow (from Step 2) downward into the sclera with a circular blending stroke using the same PC1076, creating soft edge transition. Reserve the upper eyelash line as your darkest line, keeping the lower lash line softer and more diffuse.

COLORS



PC914 Cream



PC1079 Blue Violet Lake



PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *The sclera-to-skin transition is where many portraits fail — if the eye white is too bright, the eye pops unnaturally; if it's too yellow, it reads sickly. Cream holds the midtone ground, and the cool blue-violet in the lower lid recession creates a believable eye socket without harsh shadow lines.*

05 Step 5: Base Warm Skin Tone – Full Face (Light Pressure, Even Pass)

Entire visible face and neck, all surfaces

Thin, even horizontal or directional strokes at very light pressure across entire face and neck; establish unified base before any local deepening; work around pre-colored features (eyes, lips).

Light pressure

Lay down the dominant measured skin color uniformly across the ENTIRE face at very light pressure before any local deepening or area-by-area variation. Using PC1084 (Ginger Root), apply thin, even horizontal strokes from one side of the face to the other, covering forehead, cheeks, nose, jaw, and neck with consistent light coverage. This pass should feel barely-there — the goal is even saturation of the base hue across all skin zones, not modeling yet. Work carefully around the eye sockets and lips (preserve the dark and colored areas already placed), but ensure no skin area is left paper-white. This foundational evenness prevents the 'patchy skin' problem by establishing unified color across the entire zone before adding shadow depth or highlight warm-up.

COLORS ☒ PC1084 Ginger Root

✦ *This is the single most important unification step in portrait work — resist the urge to deepen shadow areas yet. Build color in thin, full-zone passes rather than area-by-area detail, and the portrait will read cohesive rather than piecemeal.*

06 Step 6: Shadow Plane Build – Warm Chromatic Underpainting (Measured Color Match)

Shadow side of face, cheek recession, jaw line, under-nose, nasolabial folds, neck underside

Warm chromatic shadow layer following measured reference; directional strokes that follow form anatomy; defined shadow plane edge with clear value break between lit and shadow; no neutral grey allowed.

Medium pressure

Define the three-dimensional form by placing warm (not neutral grey) chromatic shadows in the turning planes of the face. Using PC1099 (Espresso, measured #59473e match) and PC941 (Light Umber, measured #8d6651 match), block the shadow planes with medium pressure, following the anatomy — core shadow on the cheek turning away from light, shadow under the cheekbone, along the jaw edge, and the soft shadow recess under the lower lip. These shadows must read as warm chromatic undertone (olive-brown, not grey-blue), staying true to the measured reference color. Apply strokes with directional pressure that follows the surface form — horizontal strokes on the cheek plane, downward strokes along the jawline. The shadow edge (where lit meets shadow) should have a defined break, not a soft blur across the whole area. This creates the dimensional 'turning' that reads as three-dimensional structure.

COLORS ● PC1099 Espresso ● PC941 Light Umber

✦ *The most common mistake here is painting shadows too neutral and too soft — the reference clearly shows warm espresso and umber undertones in the shadows, not cool grey. A defined core shadow edge (not blurred out) is what reads as form turning; soft blending comes later as a final unification step.*

07 Step 7: Mid-Tone Form Building – Optical Mixing Layer

Cheeks, upper face, nose bridge, and forehead — mid-lit zones

Mid-tone optical mixing with warm brown and warm grey; directional strokes following surface form; light-to-medium pressure; blend into light base and dark shadow at edges using circular blending.

Light to Medium pressure

Layer PC1080 (Beige Sienna, measured #b29376 match) and PC1056 (70% Warm Grey, measured #6a594e match) as optical mixing undertones in the mid-face, especially across the cheek apples, nose bridge, and upper forehead. These colors sit between the shadow darks and the light highlights, building dimensional form without jumping directly to extremes. Apply at light-to-medium pressure with directional strokes that follow the surface — horizontal across cheeks, downward along the nose. Blend these mid-tones into both the light base (from Step 5) and the dark shadows (from Step 6) using circular blending strokes at the transition edges, creating soft gradation without hard lines. This layer adds saturation and warmth to the mid-face where natural skin redness and form volume concentrate.

COLORS ☒ PC1080 Beige Sienna ☐ PC1056 70% Warm Grey

✦ *Optical mixing (layering distinct hues thinly so they optically blend on paper rather than pre-mixing) creates luminosity that single colors cannot achieve. Beige Sienna plus Warm Grey plus the Ginger Root base below optically mix into rich, dimensional skin tone that reads alive.*

08 Step 8: Facial Accent Colors – Cheek Blush and Lip Definition

Cheek apples, upper lips, and nose tip

Concentrated cheek blush in circular strokes at apple of cheek; lips layered with warm rose and henna, upper darker and cooler, lower lighter and warmer; horizontal light texture strokes in lips; nose tip peach accent.

Medium (cheeks); Light to Medium (lips and nose) pressure

Punch saturation into the cheeks and lips using PC1017 (Clay Rose) at medium pressure, applied in small circular strokes centered on the apples of the cheeks (roughly one finger-width below the outer corner of the eye). The cheek color should feel concentrated and localized, not spread across the whole face — this is where natural flush sits. For lips, layer the upper lip slightly darker with PC1031 (Henna, a warm dark rose) at light-medium pressure, keeping the line soft and integrated into surrounding skin (never a hard outline). Layer the lower lip with PC1017 (Clay Rose) at slightly lighter pressure, as the lower lip catches more light and appears warmer and more saturated than the upper lip. Add a tiny accent of PC939 (Peach) to the nose tip where light strikes most directly. Keep all lip strokes horizontal and light, suggesting texture rather than overfilling the shape.

COLORS



PC1017 Clay Rose



PC1031 Henna



PC939 Peach

✦ *Lips are rarely the same color as face skin — upper lip reads cooler and darker (the shadowed side of the lip volume), while lower lip is the light-catching dome and reads warmer and brighter. Horizontal texture strokes, laid very light at the end, suggest the natural creases that make lips read three-dimensional rather than a solid shape.*

09 Step 9: Skin Unification and Temperature Balancing (Full-Face Glaze)

Entire face and visible neck — all skin zones

Full-face glaze with very light pressure horizontal strokes; rosy beige warm-neutral harmonizing color; gentle circular blending at transitions; soft integration without erasing core shadows.

Light pressure

Before moving to hair or detailed refinement, unify the face with a soft glaze layer that harmonizes the temperature shifts and blends hard edges from previous layers. Using PC1019 (Rosy Beige) at very light pressure, apply thin horizontal strokes across the entire face, including shadow zones, lit zones, and accent areas. This warm-neutral pink beige acts as a 'temperature bridge' — it softens the contrast between the warm base and cool accents without turning the face grey or muddy. Work with gentle circular blending motions at shadow-to-light transitions, softening the defined plane edges slightly while preserving core shadow definition. This pass should feel like a whisper — it's not meant to erase previous work, but to knit it together. Pay special attention to the face-to-neck transition, ensuring the glaze extends evenly so neck doesn't read as a separate color block.

COLORS ☒ PC1019 Rosy Beige

✦ *This is the unification step that transforms a collection of colored layers into a cohesive portrait. The glaze should feel translucent enough that you see previous layers through it; if it's opaque, you're using too much pressure and erasing your dimensional work. Think 'light veil,' not 'new layer.'*

10 Step 10: Hair Foundation – Dark Root and Direction Building

Full hair mass from roots to tips; focus on root density and directional flow

Full-length directional strokes from root to tip with decreasing pressure; dense dark at roots (heavy pressure), thinning toward tips; dark clumps separated by light spaces; warm espresso undertone for dimensional richness; preserve paper tooth for highlights.

Heavy at roots; decreases toward tips pressure

Establish hair as a three-dimensional form, not a flat dark shape. Using PC1076 (90% French Grey) and PC935 (Black), start at the roots and crown with heavy pressure to create maximum depth — hair is darkest where it grows closest together and where light cannot penetrate the density. Apply full-length strokes that follow the actual direction of hair growth (whether flowing down, pinned up, or layered) at decreasing pressure from root to tip, so the tips stay lighter and softer. Never render every individual strand — instead, render the light pattern across the whole mass by creating clumps of dark separated by lighter spaces where the light travels. Layer PC1099 (Espresso) as a warm undertone through parts of the dark mass to prevent it from reading as pure black and lifeless; dark hair is built from dark brown, navy, and warm undertones, never single-channel black. Preserve significant paper tooth (do not burnish hair yet) for the highlight pattern to come.

COLORS

● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC935 Black

● PC1099 Espresso

✦ *Hair fails when it's rendered as one uniform dark mass — successful hair reads as light traveling across a dimensional three-dimensional form. The key is starting dark at the densest point (the roots and crown where hair grows thickest) and consistently decreasing pressure as you move toward the tips and lighter areas, letting paper white and light greys show through.*

11 Step 11: Hair Highlight Pattern and Light Passage

Across the hair mass wherever light would naturally catch highlights and create a sense of flow and dimension

Partial-length strokes (not full tips) suggesting light passage; warm peach-beige undertone in highlights; preserve directional flow and clump structure from Step 10; white only for brightest accent points; light pressure with strategic placement.

Light to Medium pressure

Define the light pattern on the hair surface using lighter colors that suggest the direction of the light source and the form of the hair volume. Using PC1085 (Peach Beige) and PC1084 (Ginger Root) at light-to-medium pressure, apply partial-length strokes (not full root-to-tip) along the light-facing surfaces of the hair, especially along the crown, temples where hair catches directional light, and any wisps or texture edges. Avoid creating a stripe pattern — instead, suggest soft, broken light passages that follow the growth direction and clump structure established in Step 10. Layer these light passages with PC938 (White) applied at very light pressure in just the brightest hit-points (the apex of the crown, any flyaway wisps in bright light) — this creates the final luminous quality. The highlight pattern should reinforce the three-dimensional form: more pronounced highlights on the lit side, softer or absent highlights on the shadow side of the hair.

COLORS ☒ PC1085 Peach Beige ☒ PC1084 Ginger Root ☒ PC938 White

✦ *The highlight pattern is what separates three-dimensional hair rendering from flat dark shapes. Observe the reference carefully — light doesn't hit hair evenly; it creates soft passages and brightest points. Broken, directional light strokes (not continuous stripes) read as natural texture and volume.*

12 Step 12: Neck Form and Self-Shadow – Defined Plane Separation

Entire visible neck, from jawline to collarbone; focus on soft self-shadow under the jaw

Lit neck side extends face base color downward; shadow underside (under-jaw recess) with defined plane break using warm grey and espresso; clear soft edge separating lit from shadow plane; blend junction with very light rosy beige glaze preserving shadow definition.

Light (face extension); Medium (shadow plane); Light (blending glaze) pressure

Establish the neck as a dimensional form connecting the face to the body. The neck naturally carries a softer self-shadow on its underside (where the jaw overhangs and light cannot reach), and this shadow must be defined, not blurred into the whole neck. Layer the lit side of the neck (facing the light source) with PC1084 (Ginger Root) at light pressure to extend the face base color downward. For the shadow side and the soft recess under the jawline, apply PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) and PC1099 (Espresso) at medium pressure, creating a clear plane break where the lit neck surface meets the shadowed underside. The underside shadow should have a defined soft edge (not blurred, but not hard either) that reads as the neck turning away. Blend the jaw-to-neck junction with a circular blending stroke using PC1019 (Rosy Beige) at very light pressure, softening the transition while preserving the shadow plane definition. The neck should read as a cylindrical form, not a flat extension of the face.

COLORS ● PC1084 Ginger Root ● PC1056 70% Warm Grey ● PC1099 Espresso
● PC1019 Rosy Beige

✦ *The under-jaw shadow is often the first place a portrait reads three-dimensional — a soft, defined shadow plane under the jawline immediately reads as form turning, not flat illustration. Keep this shadow warm (never neutral grey), and keep the edge defined so the volume reads convincingly.*

13 Step 13: Neck-to-Garment Edge and Garment Color Integration

Garment at the lower frame boundary, especially collar or neckline edge where garment meets skin; reflected color from garment onto lower jaw and neck

Garment blocked with very dark grey-black at heavy pressure; soft but defined edge line at garment-skin junction; subtle reflected color glaze (warm grey) on skin side of edge; fold structure defined with mid-dark grey; preserve reference geometry.

Heavy (garment block); Light (reflected color glaze); Medium (fold structure) pressure

Define where the skin ends and the garment begins with careful edge work and reflected color consideration. The garment in the reference reads as very dark (near-black, measured as #2e2b2e and #050a14) — block this with PC1076 (90% French Grey) and PC935 (Black) at heavy pressure below the neckline. Where the garment edge meets the skin (at the jaw and neck boundary), apply a very light glaze of PC1056 (70% Warm Grey) on the skin side of the line to suggest subtle reflected color bounce from the dark fabric onto the warm neck skin — this is a professional finishing touch that prevents the hard line from feeling stuck-on. Keep the garment edge line soft but defined, not blurred. If there is any collar detail or fold, follow the reference geometry and use PC1074 (70% French Grey) for half-shadow surfaces to suggest three-dimensional fabric structure. Never use pure black for the garment — the dark grey anchors the value hierarchy and maintains color unity with the hair and eye shadows.

COLORS ☒ PC1076 90% French Grey ☒ PC935 Black ☒ PC1056 70% Warm Grey
☒ PC1074 70% French Grey

✦ *The garment-to-skin edge is a common place where portraits fail if treated carelessly — either the edge is too hard (looks pasted on) or too soft (reads blurred and cheap). A soft edge with a hint of reflected color warmth on the skin side reads professional and intentional. The very dark garment also serves a compositional function: it frames and darkens the lower border, pushing visual attention toward the face.*

14 Step 14: Fine Detail and Texture – Eye Lashes, Nostril Shadows, Skin Texture

Upper and lower eyelashes, nostrils, pores and micro-texture on nose and cheeks

Sharp fine-point pencil for lashes and texture dots; upper lashes crisp and individual, lower lashes diffuse; nostril shadow soft but distinct; skin texture via light micro-dots and short lines at very light pressure; work small sections at a time.

Light (lashes and texture); Medium (nostril shadow) pressure

Add the sharp, fine details that anchor the portrait in photorealism and draw the viewer's eye to the face. Using a freshly sharpened PC935 (Black) at light pressure, place fine individual upper eyelashes using short, angled strokes that follow the natural lash line curvature — upper lashes should be crisp and defined, creating the single sharpest line of the portrait besides the pupil. Lower lashes are less defined; use PC1076 (90% French Grey) at very light pressure to suggest them as a diffuse line rather than individual hairs. For nostrils, darken the recess with PC1099 (Espresso) at medium pressure, keeping the nostril shadow soft but distinct. On the nose tip and cheeks, add micro-texture by placing tiny dots or short light lines with PC1080 (Beige Sienna) or PC941 (Light Umber) at very light pressure — this creates the illusion of skin texture and pores without overdoing it. Work on a small area at a time using a sharp pencil; macro-detail erases quickly if overdone, so start subtle.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC941 Light Umber

✦ *Detail is the final tool for drawing the eye — sharp eyelashes make the eye feel alive and real, while a few subtle skin texture dots on the nose and cheeks prevent the face from reading waxy or over-smooth. However, restraint is key: you want texture to be noticed unconsciously, not as obvious speckles. Less is always more with fine detail.*

15 Step 15: Chromatic Shadow Refinement – Cool Undertone Enhancement in Shadow Zones

Eye sockets, under-eye, nasolabial folds, under-chin shadow, and all shadow plane recesses

Very light pressure transparent glazes of blue-violet and cool grey into shadow zones; cool undertone accent over warm shadow base creates optical depth; preserve warm cheek and lip saturation; work as transparent veil, not opaque layer.

Light pressure

Deepen and cool the shadow zones with a light glaze of blue-violet and cool undertones, which creates dimensional color separation and prevents shadows from reading muddy or flat. Using PC1079 (Blue Violet Lake) at very light pressure, apply thin glazes into the eye sockets (especially the upper eyelid shadow and under-eye recess) and the nasolabial fold shadows. Layer PC1074 (70% French Grey) at very light pressure into the cheek shadow plane, adding cool undertone without erasing the warm chromatic darks beneath. The goal is not to turn shadows cool or grey, but to add cool accent that optically brightens and clarifies the warm shadow base — cool undertone over warm base creates dimensional color separation that reads as depth. Apply these cool glazes at very light pressure so they feel like transparent veils, not new opaque layers. Work carefully around the cheek blush and lip areas, leaving those warm saturations intact.

COLORS



PC1079 Blue Violet Lake



PC1074 70% French Grey

✦ *The human eye reads 'depth' partly through chromatic color separation — warm highlights against cool shadows read more three-dimensional than warm highlights against neutral grey shadows. This cool undertone step is the professional-level finishing technique that separates dimensional portraits from flat ones. The cool glaze should feel subtle; if it's obvious, you've used too much pressure.*

16 Step 16: Peak Highlights and Light Accent – True Bright Punch (Addressing Highlight Correction)

Brightest light-struck points: forehead apex, bridge of nose, nose tip, upper cheekbone peaks, center of lower lip, and eye specular highlight confirmation

White pencil at medium-to-heavy pressure placed at light-struck peaks; small concentrated points and short directional streaks, not scattered dots; hard value break from surrounding midtone; follow surface anatomy (nose tip, cheekbone peak, forehead apex); step back to verify reads as light-struck, not evenly filled.

Medium to Heavy pressure

This step addresses the recurring issue that this artist's brightest lights plateau at cream and never reach a true luminous peak. Push the lightest zones all the way to near-white brightness with a sharp value jump from the surrounding midtone, so the form reads as **STRUCK BY LIGHT**, not evenly filled. Using PC938 (White) at medium-to-heavy pressure, place definitive bright accents at the apex of the forehead (where light rounds the form), the bridge and tip of the nose, and the peak of the lit cheekbone. These highlights should be small, concentrated points or short streaks that follow the surface form — not splotchy or scattered. Reserve the eye specular highlight (placed in Step 2) as your single brightest element. On the lower lip, add a thin white line at the edge where the light strikes the wet surface texture. Each highlight should create a hard value break from its surrounding midtone — this contrast is what reads as luminosity and light directionality. Step back and view the portrait from a distance: the highlights should immediately read as light sources, not as part of the local color.

COLORS ☒ PC938 White

✦ *Many colored pencil portraits feel flat because the brightest lights are merely 'lighter,' not truly bright. A hard highlight at MAXIMUM value (near-white) against a medium surrounding value reads as luminosity and light source — this is not optional detail, it's structural to portrait impact. Don't be timid with white highlights on the nose bridge and cheekbone; that's the difference between 'well-rendered' and 'luminous.'*

17 Step 17: Burnishing Pass – Smooth Integration and Value Unification

Entire face and neck, with emphasis on mid-tone and highlight zones

Colorless blender at heavy pressure in circular overlapping strokes across lit face and neck; compress pencil layers into seamless surface, fuse all marks; follow with white or cream at heavy pressure for final luminous glaze; light touch on eyes and darks; methodical full-coverage pass.

Heavy (blender); Heavy (light pencil glaze) pressure

Burnishing is the final smoothing and integration step that creates the polished, photorealistic surface. Using a colorless Prismacolor blender at heavy pressure, burnish across all skin zones (especially the lit side of the face, forehead, cheeks, and nose) in circular, overlapping motions. Work methodically from the center face outward, letting the blender compress the pencil layers and fuse them into a seamless surface with no visible paper texture or white flecks. Follow up with PC938 (White) or PC914 (Cream) at heavy pressure in the same circular pattern — this is a light burnishing pass that adds a final luminous cream glaze and ensures any pencil wax bloom (the slight haze that appears after burnishing) is addressed. For shadow zones, use less pressure or skip burnishing entirely to preserve the defined plane edges and chromatic richness of the dark layers. Be cautious not to over-burnish the eyes — a light touch in the iris and sclera area preserves detail, while the face and neck can handle maximum burnishing.

COLORS ☒ PC938 White ☐ PC914 Cream

✦ *Burnishing is not optional for portraits — it's what transforms a colored-pencil rendering from 'visible layers' into 'painted surface.' The circular overlapping motion is key: each pass should overlap the previous 50%, creating smooth, even compression. One light pass with a light pencil after the colorless blender smooths any wax bloom and adds subtle warmth without erasing detail.*

18 Step 18: Post-Burnish Shadow Darkening and Final Detail (Wax Bloom Correction)

Entire face, especially shadow zones and mid-tone areas; return to any areas that lightened during burnishing

Selective shadow re-darkening at light-to-medium pressure in form-defining zones (eye sockets, folds, jaw underside); mid-tone warmth reinforcement with rosy beige or ginger root at very light pressure; sharp final line work on eyes; surgical precision, not full re-working.

Light to Medium (shadows); Light (mid-tone warmth); Light (line work) pressure

Burnishing lightens values slightly (called 'wax bloom'), so this final pass corrects by re-darkening shadows and restoring punch to mid-tones. Using PC1099 (Espresso) and PC1076 (90% French Grey) at light-to-medium pressure, selectively re-layer the eye sockets, nasolabial folds, under-jaw shadow, and cheek shadow plane to restore their depth. This is not a full re-paint — it's targeted reinforcement of the form-defining shadows. Layer PC1084 (Ginger Root) or PC1019 (Rosy Beige) at very light pressure across any mid-face zones that feel washed out from burnishing, restoring warmth without opacity. Finally, use a sharp PC935 (Black) or PC1076 to sharpen the upper eyelid line and pupil rim, ensuring the eye remains the darkest, sharpest feature. This step should feel surgical and light — you're not rebuilding the portrait, just restoring the tonal range that burnishing slightly compressed. Step back and compare to the reference: shadows should read defined, highlights should read bright, and the face should feel three-dimensional and luminous.

COLORS ☒ PC1099 Espresso ☒ PC1076 90% French Grey ☒ PC1084 Ginger Root
☒ PC1019 Rosy Beige ☒ PC935 Black

✦ *This correction step separates professional portraits from those that feel slightly flat — many artists skip this and accept the slight value loss from burnishing. Don't. Re-darkening shadows and sharpening the eye in the final pass is what restores the portrait's dimension and visual impact. Work lightly and strategically; this is refinement, not redoing.*

Evaluate Your Result

Upload your finished drawing to Claude and use this prompt:

"I followed a colored pencil portrait tutorial. Here's what I was trying to achieve: [describe the portrait].
Here's what I think went well: [your observation].
Here's what I'm not satisfied with: [your concern].
Give me 2-3 specific things to improve and rate the result 1-10."

Guide #010 · Pencil & Prompt

This guide was part of an ongoing series — each one AI-generated, human-executed, fully documented.

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